Virtuoso Literature for Two and Four Hands

By Diane Wakoski

INTRODUCTION

Nothing is simple or innocent any more except poetry and music. Love is definitely not a simple or innocent concept. Love can be complicated, messy, misunderstood, and tragic, even. Love, like gravity, is a force not to be reckoned with. We try to bridle it, we try to contain it, we try to create it and destroy it and it plays by its own rules. Love can be beautiful and it can be painful, but it's always real. Virtuoso Literature for Two and Four Hands by Diane Wakoski.

Memory relies on emotion. No other part of the mind
does.

A night near New Year's Eve, in New York City. I do not
remember if it was raining,
but it was either cold or damp,
weather that affects you like someone tracking mud
onto your freshly scrubbed kitchen floor,

and my life was falling apart,
that is
the man I loved was running away from me as if I were a

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leaking ceiling or a broken step, and he,
a homeowner, fatigued,
eschewing one more repair.

A party in a prosperous uptown apartment was something
to do,
voices, faces, fragrant and effulgent,
like gardenias on a hothouse tree,
forced in a December greenhouse,

the story of that night is a story of waiting,
a story of waiting for a hand which was not there to
touch me on the shoulder and say, "Let's
go home," a story of waiting
for a carpenter in a land where there are no trees, a
story of waiting,
waiting,

except for one moment which I remember,
like an afterimage from bright light:
a man,
an old friend,
a writer and teacher,
sat down at the piano/ he was drunk and nostalgic,
and bending over the keys like the limbs of a willow,
he played "Stella By Starlight,"
here in this company of intellectuals and poets,
he forgot where he was.
He forgot the rain and the evening of talk,
and played as if he were in some 1940s piano bar,

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a song none of us knew the words to,
here in this company of intellectuals and poets
he played "Stella By Starlight"
this man who read Blake and Reich and Vallejo,
who listened to Bruchner in his spare time,
who did not believe in popular art,
even Bob Dylan or the Rolling Stones whom we all
listened to. He sat there
and with reverence
played "Stella By Starlight"
And I remember that part of the evening better than
anything else.

Though I later went to a jazz club and heard exciting
Pharaoh Sanders,
though I later sat desperately with a man who asked me
why,
why I was faithful to that man I loved,
the one who wanted nothing to do with me,
and I could not answer.
I could not answer.

I could not answer,
because the simple answer,
the true answer,
was one I could not believe.
Nothing is simple or innocent any
more, except poetry and music.
A night near Thanksgiving,
in Wisconsin, snow crystals blowing through the air,
an owl in the nearby woods

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reminding me that I am alone,
"a woman alone"
(my mother always referred to herself as "a woman
alone" /
I learned it was a desperate and terrible condition).
I visit friends.
- They too have a piano in their living room,
gleaming in the dark, like brandied cherries
in a flat french bottle.

Whenever my life falls apart, I am reminded
that I still have not fallen apart.
The owl speaking alone in the woods, the one
we never see; we know he is waiting for a small soft
creature like a mouse, to snap the backbone in half,
and that this
is not cruel but simply his means of sustaining life.

The piano glows in Mary and Walter's living room,
the luster of the wood is like well polished boots
promising the hands and feet someplace to go.
I feel the energy of the piano and remember my old
friend, writer and teacher,
who sat down and played,
so lovingly,
"Stella By Starlight"

sun
moon
stars
minerals and fire which liberate us from earth & water

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and I tell them my meager story,
wondering why we are not satisfied with our minds
unless our hands can do their share.

As if in a story, myself,
I tell them of my promise when I was twenty-one
not to touch the piano again,
to take the motion of my hands
and transform it
into the energy of my life,
and then I confess that I feel the piano vibrating in the next room, like a nova, an exploding star, one whose heat and light I cannot resist,

and I go in to the piano with my hands on fire
and sit down and play old Chopin preludes/ my fingers
have not touched the keyboard for fifteen years,
they do not respond automatically,
but they remember patterns, they remember rhythms,
they remember chords and keys,
and they do not wait,
they do not wait,
they touch the keyboard, I sway, bending my body like a willow tree, one which will weep for me.
I do not know "Stella By Starlight" but I know Chopin,
and I let my friends hear me,
how badly I play now
I remember the pleasure of touching
sun

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moon
stars
that owl lonely in the woods obsidian and ivory
the hard rocks of life

they did not ask me
why
I do not play, why I am faithful to my promise though touching the keys means so much
to me,
They knew I could not answer,
or rather,
that I could
but that my answer
would not be an
answer.

Nothing is simple or innocent any more,
including poetry and music?
My friend, the astronomer, cannot recognize the constellations in the sky. They are not math or science.
He honors truth,
not poetry.

A night in spring,
Colorado mountain air, like razors near the cheek,
my husband and I entering a mountain resort bar,
a place where they serve beer in half-yards, steak and kidney pie
is on the menu,
the entertainment is an old lady

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named "Juneau Hattie" who plays ragtime piano.
We sit among business men and college boys,
someone from Sigma Chi having a birthday,
middle-aged tourists drunk and revealing marital fears,
"My mother was afraid I would marry the first man in uniform who came along. . .
and I did"

drinking Irish coffee,
thin and steamy against the cold night

outside.
We are together and happy.
My hands move along with the piano player's hands.
She is thumping out
"My Wild Irish Rose," "Take Me Out To The Ball Game,"
the exposed hammers above her keyboard moving
the way they must move every night for her.

She is over fifty, wears a green silk dress, Hong Kong style, slit up the sides; and a little green hat she may have made herself. Thin legs, like sticks, under a chunky body that hammers out tunes we members of the bourgeoisie can sing together.
I think of her playing every night, every night having to be gay, a party, wondering how she can do it,
knowing that we all
always
are on stage,
that we all do it,
though each day gets harder.

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How can she bear to play those same songs every night, put the same emotion into them?
My friend and I,
the man who played "Stella By Starlight," and I, who was moved to confess to the keys my longing for them last winter,
could we be moved
more than once?
He,
had he played "Stella By Starlight" any time in the past ten years?
Will he again,
in ten more?
I, ,
holding my hands away from the pianos I have passed, like a hiker in the hot dry mountains refusing to open his canteen of water until he is absolutely sure he could not continue without it,
taking a sip,
and saving the rest for another
desperate time,
I yielding that one night to Chopin in winter

and knowing that I would not be so tempted again for at least fifteen more years. . .

Drinking Irish coffee, listening to this music-hall performer who probably makes little more money than will pay her rent, buy her Irish whiskey;
sitting with a man I love,
one who cares for me,

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wondering how
we renew
our emotions each day,
wondering what it means to have a simple desire
with a simple response.
Nothing is simple or innocent any more, except poetry
and music.

When I speak,
I hear many other voices,
like a tv store with the sets all tuned to different
channels,
When I listen,
I no longer can identify voices,
often
do not know the words of songs, cannot remember
the names of
pieces.
When I type the word "piano"
my fingers often slip.
They spell "pain" Oh,
how do we do it?
Get from day to day, when nothing is simple or innocent,
not even poetry or music?

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